Why bother to create an illustration?



Fair question! The exhibited poster with all its illustrations and layout indeed took roughly 40-50 hours.

Why would someone invest that much effort instead of just using the simpler design of text?

The first argument is: time. We all have too little of it and reading is a fairly slow consumption of information. Apparently we manage to read at a speed of 252 ms per word (Brysbaert, 2019). Looking at digesting a scene like an illustration, we grasp the context, meaning and message within 150 ms (Thorpe et al., 1996). Now you can do the math yourself to think of how many words are required to give you the context, meaning and message of a scene.

If time isn't your bottleneck, you should think about what you actually understand based on language or based on visuals. In a comparison Houts et al. (1998) compared the recall of information based on either solely spoken instructions or combined with a visual. 85% of the content was recalled when supported by a visual and only 14% of the content when only using language.

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Wouldn't a simple chart be enough then?

Not quite, embellished charts outperform simple charts, even for recalling information after a time period of 2-3 weeks (Bateman et al., 2010).

Enough about infographics, let's focus on this infographic: How do people aged 15 - 29 year old spent their time on a daily basis? And which trends and patterns evolve when comparing from the year 1991 up until 2022?

Bateman, S., Mandryk, R. L., Gutwin, C., Genest, A., McDine, D., & Brooks, C. (2010). Useful junk?: The effects of visual embellishment on comprehension and memorability of charts. https://doi.org/10.1145/1753326.1753716

Brysbaert, M. (2019). How many words do we read per minute? A review and meta-analysis of reading rate. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jml.2019.104047

Houts, P. S., Bachrach, R., Witmer, J. T., Tringali, C. A., Bucher, J. A., & Localio, R. A. (1998). Using pictographs to enhance recall of spoken medical instructions. https://doi.org/10.1016/S0738-3991(98)00065-2

Thorpe, S., Fize, D., & Marlot, C. (1996). Speed of processing in the human visual system. https://doi.org/10.1038/381520a0